7.65 percent of the voting power.[14] Compared to the ADB's asset base of approximately $160 billion and $30 billion in loans, however, the AIIB has a long way to go in reaching a size commensurate with its ambitions. Initially capitalized at $100 billion, by the end of 2016, $89 billion was subscribed and $19.6 billion of the $20 billion in authorized capital was committed to projects. Yet only $1.7 billion in loans was disbursed its first year, with $2 billion slated for 2017, and $7.5 billion in 2018.[15] By comparison, the Japan-dominated ADB made $35.8 billion in loans in 2018, far outstripping the AIIB. Moreover, the yen remains the third-most popular currency for international transactions, after the dollar and euro, well ahead of the Chinese renminbi.[16]

For many in Asia the apparent aid and finance rivalry between China and Japan is welcome. Officials from countries that desperately need infrastructure, such as Indonesia, hope that there will be a virtuous cycle in the ADB-AIIB competition, with Japan's high social and environmental standards helping to improve the quality of China's loans, and China's lower cost structure making projects more affordable. With an estimated need for $26 trillion in infrastructure development by 2030, according to the ADB, the more sources of financing and aid the better, even if Tokyo and Beijing view both financial institutions as tools for larger strategic and political goals.

Chinese president Xi Jinping has pegged the AIIB to his ambitious—some would say grandiose—One Belt One Road (OBOR) initiative, essentially turning the new bank into an infrastructure-lending facility along with the older China Development Bank and the newer Silk Road Fund. In comparison to Japan, China has focused most of its overseas aid on infrastructure, and the OBOR serves as the latest and largest incarnation of that priority. It is the OBOR, once known as the "new Silk Road," that represents one of the key challenges to Japan's economic presence in Asia. At the inaugural Belt and Road Forum, held in Beijing in May 2017, Xi pledged $1 trillion of infrastructure investment spanning Eurasia and beyond, essentially attempting to link land- and sea-based trading routes in a new global economic architecture. Copying a page from the ADB, Xi also promised that the